

"As many as 80 per cent of the fatalities on the road involve pedestrians as their safety issues are ignored."

S. GANGOPADHYAY, Director, Central Road Research Institute



BEHIND THE BLOODBATH

- High incidence of drunk driving and increasing incidents of road rage
- Penalties for rash and negligent driving not strict enough to act as a major deterrent
- First-aid and medical support apparatus for accident victims virtually absent. Experts say fatality rates can be drastically reduced if victims get proper treatment in time.
- Poor maintenance and overloading of vehicles along with high congestion on highways. Expressways have increased average speed without introducing safety measures.
- Most highways and expressways do not have overbridges or subways
- Poor road design as road construction industry is highly unorganised; there is no record of the number of contractors, their background or capabilities
- Homeless people who sleep and live on pavements are vulnerable, especially at night due to poor lighting and rash driving

traffic rules is relatively slack, according to the study carried out by the National Institute of Mental Health and Neuro Sciences (NIMHANS), Bangalore.

The biggest killer, however, can be seen when you stand at any point overlooking a major thoroughfare and key traffic points in any big city. What you will see and hear is a ear-splitting cacophony of blaring horns and human voices screaming curses as both slow and fast-moving traffic jostle for space on roads that lack segregation. Pedestrians, cyclists, bullock carts, tractors and two-wheelers compete with cars, trucks and buses, all driving at varying speeds. Many vehicles are poorly maintained—gridlock is one result, accidents another.

Another issue is that while expressways and flyways are meant to allow traffic to move faster, they have no provision for slow-moving traffic like overloaded trucks, tempos and even tractors. The GSRRS report makes a special mention of the first project in India that aims to segregate traffic in Delhi. The first phase of the much-maligned Bus Rapid Transit (BRT) corridor has been operational for about a year now and no motorcycle or bicycle fatality has been reported so far along this stretch. While the jury is still out, accidents on expressways because of mixed traffic continue to increase. In a bizarre accident on the Noida-Greater Noida Expressway, seven people, including three policemen, were killed

while trying to rescue another accident victim after an overloaded tractor trolley overturned when one of its wheels came off.

Ultimately, however, it is the total lack of traffic sense, reckless drivers and poor driving skills that cause most road deaths. Gangopadhyay says that as many as 80 per cent of road accidents are caused by the faulty behaviour of road users. "There are no rules as long as we fail to provide road users with relevant information through proper signages, traffic lights, zebra crossings and training people to drive properly. How would you enforce lane discipline if you do not have lanes marked on the road?" he asks. He adds that faulty bus stand designs and im-

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PER CENT OF ROAD ACCIDENT DEATHS ARE OF MALES AND 70 PER CENT OF THEM ARE IN THE WORKING AGE GROUP OF 30 TO 59 YEARS.